

EU already applying new merger rulebook, Ribera says

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By Francesca Micheletti · Sep 7, 2026, 1:19 PM · [View in your browser](#)

BRUSSELS — The European Commission is already applying the principles of its draft merger guidelines to deal reviews, competition chief Teresa Ribera has said.

Speaking at a conference at the OECD in Paris on Monday, Ribera flagged the Commission's recent examination of a joint venture between Airbus and Air France as an example of "where we engaged very early on with the parties on efficiencies according to our new approach."

Air France-KLM and Airbus have joined forces to provide Airbus A350 component maintenance services worldwide — a deal that Brussels examined and cleared last April. The companies told the Commission early on that the deal would create efficiencies, paving the way for a smooth clearance, the EU executive said at the time.

The Commission is revamping its guidelines for merger assessment to include broader parameters such as innovation, resilience and investment — which it refers to as "efficiencies." The guidelines will be finalized by the end of this year, Ribera confirmed.

The exercise is partly a response to criticism that the EU's antitrust rulebook is stifling mergers that would benefit the continent's economy.

Somewhat contrasting with the line taken by Commission President Ursula von der Leyen, Ribera has always cautioned that the guidelines won't suddenly allow mergers that harm competition to go through.

"A blank check for companies to merge under whatever circumstances will not make Europe more competitive," Ribera told the Paris conference. "Scale, in itself, is not a goal."

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